Bombardier Learjet

William P. Lear developed the original Learjet Model 23 from the Swiss American Aviation Corporation's projected P-16 fighter-bomber. Unsurprisingly, given its military origins, when the Learjet entered service in 1964 it exhibited performance characteristics unprecedented for a private aircraft. In 1965 a Learjet flew from Los Angeles to New York and back in under 11 hours. The eight-seat Learjet 24, introduced in 1966, flew around the world in 50 hours and 20 minutes. In addition to being able to fly long distances at impressive speeds, Learjets could also operate at higher altitudes than even jet airliners – in 1977 the Model 25 was authorized to fly at up to 51,000ft (15,550m).

The early Learjets had wingtip fuel tanks, but during the 1970s these were replaced by drag-reducing winglets. Also, in newer models turbofans took the place of the turbojet engines. Although the executive jet market became increasingly competitive in the 1980s and 1990s, Learjets held their own by constantly evolving. For example, the range on some models increased to 2,500–3,100 miles (4,000–5,000km), and the passenger capacity rose from six to nine or 10.

While the original Learjet Corporation has been through many changes (and is presently part of the Bombardier aviation empire), the Learjet aircraft remains a classic.

> "To the public, the Learjet came close to being the ultimate status symbol."
>
> **T. A. Heppenheimer**
> *A Brief History of Flight*

ADVANCED SYSTEMS
The compact cockpit of the Learjet 45 is populated with precision flight-management systems. In addition, the wide, electrically heated windscreen allows the pilots 220-degree visibility.

RECOGNIZABLE PROFILE
The distinctive front-on profile of the Learjet 45 is characterized by the two turbofan engines set at the rear of the fuselage, the tailplane positioned high on the fin, and the upturned winglets at the end of the wings (used to reduce drag).